Jetsetter

In all, twenty-four countries established diplomatic relations with the GDR in the course of 1972. Switzerland was the first Western nation to open contacts, followed by Sweden, Austria, Australia and Belgium. The United Kingdom, France and the Netherlands followed in February 1973 and the United States in December 1974.

Honecker's mood was exultant; as well it might be having achieved a personal triumph such as Ulbricht could never have matched. Thus it happened that, for the first time, as Markus Wolf noted, Honecker was able to 'explore parts of the globe hitherto closed to us', which he discovered with 'childlike enthusiasm'.

In Latin America, a close relationship was quickly forged with Chile, which was experimenting, albeit unsuccessfully, with its own socialist project. Writing from Santiago on 27 January 1972, Chilean President Salvador G. Allendes accepted Honecker's invitation to visit East Berlin, noting it 'would contribute to further strengthening the already existing ties of solidarity between Chile and the GDR'. In fact, Allende had already announced in 1969 that he would recognise the GDR under international law if he won the election (which he did in 1970. In April 1971, he made good on his promise). Since then, credits in the millions were flowing between the two countries, trade relations were close, and a lively cultural exchange programme was inaugurated. At the same time, the GDR became a member of UNESCO and set up a 'Permanent Observer Mission' at the UN headquarters and was admitted to the UN Economic Commission for Europe (ECE). 'Psychologically', it was easy to understand Honecker's drive to involve the GDR in the affairs of the wider world, according to Wolf.1 Indeed, he worked industriously at strengthening ties with other socialist countries, resulting in passport and visa-free travel with Poland, Czechoslovakia and Romania. He even proceeded in developing relations with the Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO), despite the murder of eleven Israeli athletes at the Munich Olympics, an atrocity organised by